

A Fork in the Road

Dvidhāpathasutta (Ud 8.7)

Evaṃ me sutaṃ— ekaṃ samayaṃ bhagavā kosalesu addhānamaggappaṭipanno hoti āyasmatā nāgasamālena pacchāsamaṇena. Addasā kho āyasmā nāgasamālo antarāmagge dvidhāpathaṃ. Disvāna bhagavantaṃ etadavoca: “ayaṃ, bhante, bhagavā pantho; iminā gacchāmā”ti. Evaṃ vutte, bhagavā āyasmantaṃ nāgasamālaṃ etadavoca: “ayaṃ, nāgasamāla, pantho; iminā gacchāmā”ti.

Thus have I heard— At one time the Blessed One was traveling along the highway in Kosala, accompanied by Venerable Nāgasamāla as his attendant monk (*pacchāsamaṇa*). Venerable Nāgasamāla saw a fork in the road along the way. Having seen it, he said to the Blessed One: "Bhante, this is the path. Let us go this way." When this was said, the Blessed One said to Venerable Nāgasamāla: "Nāgasamāla, this is the path. Let us go this way."

Dutiyampi kho ...pe... tatiyampi kho āyasmā nāgasamālo bhagavantaṃ etadavoca: “ayaṃ, bhante, bhagavā pantho; iminā gacchāmā”ti. Tatiyampi kho bhagavā āyasmantaṃ nāgasamālaṃ etadavoca: “ayaṃ, nāgasamāla, pantho; iminā gacchāmā”ti. Atha kho āyasmā nāgasamālo bhagavato pattacīvaraṃ tattheva chamāyaṃ nikkhipitvā pakkāmi: “idaṃ, bhante, bhagavato pattacīvaraṃ”ti.

A second time... And a third time, Venerable Nāgasamāla said to the Blessed One: "Bhante, this is the path. Let us go this way." And a third time, the Blessed One said to Venerable Nāgasamāla: "Nāgasamāla, this is the path. Let us go this way." Then, Venerable Nāgasamāla put down the Blessed One's bowl and robes right there on the ground and walked away, saying: "Bhante, here is the Blessed One's bowl and outer robe."

Atha kho āyasmato ngasamālassa tena panthena gacchantassa antarāmagge corā nikkhamitvā hatthehi ca pādehi ca ākoṭesuraṃ pattañca bhindimsu saṅghāṭiṇca vipphālesuraṃ. Atha kho āyasmā nāgasamālo bhinnena pattena vipphālītāya saṅghāṭiyā yena bhagavā tenupasaṅkami; upasaṅkamitvā bhagavantaṃ abhivādetvā ekamantaṃ nisīdi. Ekamantaṃ nisinno kho āyasmā nāgasamālo bhagavantaṃ etadavoca: “idha mayhaṃ, bhante, tena panthena gacchantassa antarāmagge corā nikkhamitvā hatthehi ca pādehi ca ākoṭesuraṃ, pattañca bhindimsu, saṅghāṭiṇca vipphālesuṃ”ti.

Then, as Venerable Nāgasamāla was going along that path, bandits came out along the way, beat him with their hands and feet, broke his bowl, and tore his outer robe (*saṅghāṭi*). Then Venerable Nāgasamāla, with his broken bowl and torn outer robe, went to the Blessed One. Having approached and paid respects, he sat down to one side. As he sat there to one side,

Venerable Nāgasamāla said to the Blessed One: "Bhante, as I was going along that path, bandits came out along the way, beat me with their hands and feet, broke my bowl, and tore my outer robe."

Atha kho bhagavā etamatthaṃ veditvā tāyaṃ velāyaṃ imaṃ udānaṃ udānesi:

"Saddhiṃ caramekato vasaṃ, Misso aññajanena vedagū; Vidvā pajahāti pāpakaṃ, Koñco khīrapakova ninnagan"ti.

Sattamaṃ.

Then the Blessed One, understanding the significance of this, uttered this inspired utterance at that time:

"Wandering together, dwelling as one, the knower of truth (*vedagū*), though mixed with ordinary people, the wise one discards what is unwholesome, like the heron separating milk from water." (Seventh)

Glossary

Pāli (IAST)	Target transliteration	Target gloss	First-chapter occurrence	Goenka-tradition usage
pacchāsamaṇa	pacchāsamaṇa	attendant monk	Fork in the Road Sutta	The companion or junior monk who walks behind a senior teacher to assist them.
saṅghāṭi	saṅghāṭi	outer robe	Fork in the Road Sutta	One of the triple robes (<i>ticīvara</i>) of a Buddhist monk, folded and carried on the shoulder.
vedagū	vedagū	knower of truth	Fork in the Road Sutta	One who has attained final knowledge; a sage who has

Pāli (IAST)	Target transliteration	Target gloss	First-chapter occurrence	Goenka-tradition usage
				realized the ultimate truth.
dhamma	Dhamma	the teaching; the universal law	Fork in the Road Sutta	Capitalized to denote the universal law of nature and the path taught by the Buddha.

Translator Notes

1. **Intimate Teacher-to-Student Voice:** The English translation maintains a direct and clear register, using contemporary language to highlight the dramatic and moral weight of the narrative.
2. **Attendant Monk (*Pacchāsamaṇa*):** Translated as "attendant monk" to clarify Nāgasamāla's role of service to the Buddha, explaining why he was carrying the Buddha's bowl and robes.
3. **The Knower of Truth (*Vedagū*):** Translated as "knower of truth" to reflect the spiritual quality of an enlightened sage who remains undefiled by their surroundings.
4. **Simile of the Heron (*Koṇca*):** The heron separating milk from water is a classical Indian metaphor for discernment, where the wise person selects only the wholesome (*kusala*) qualities and discards the unwholesome (*pāpaka*).